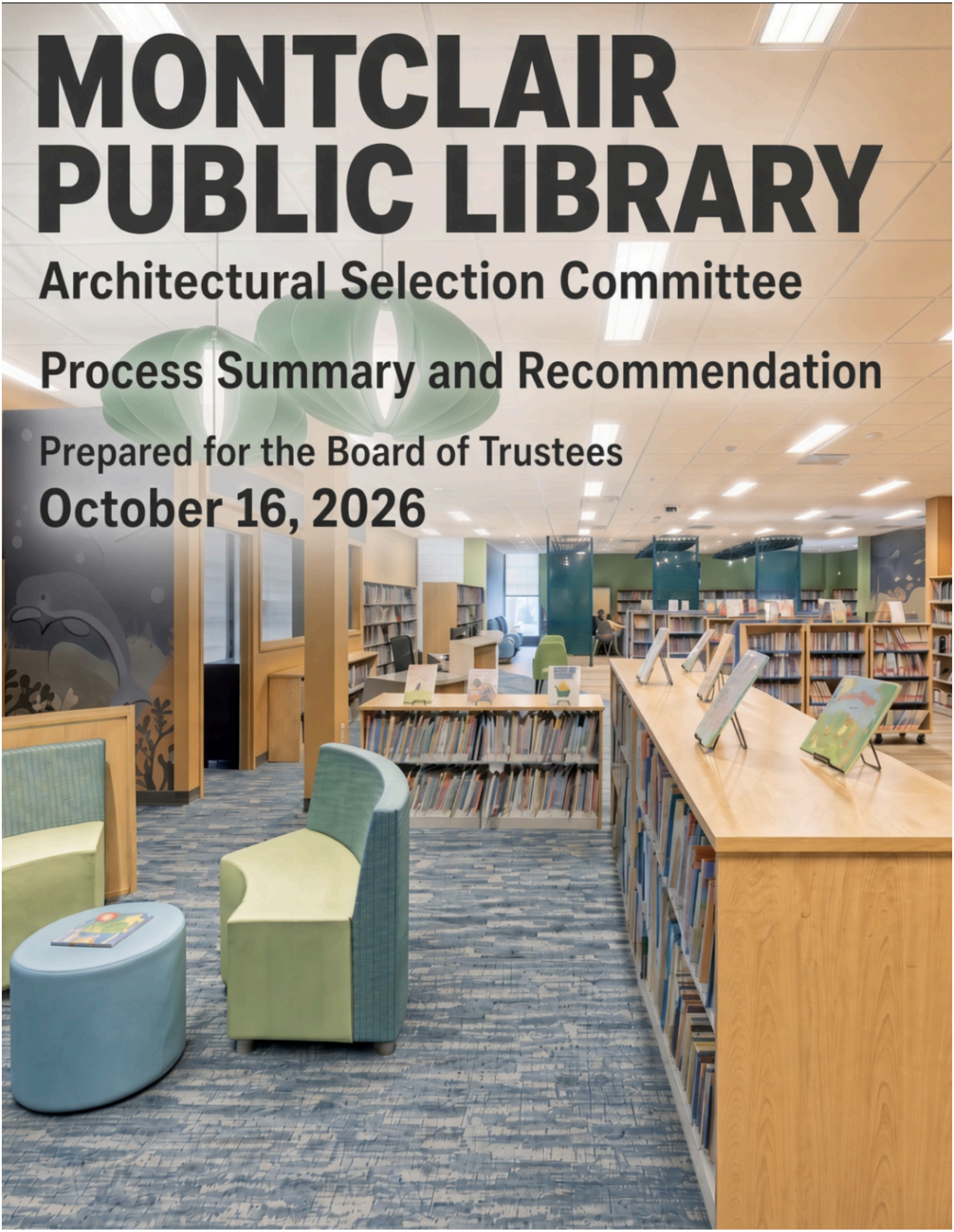


MONTCLAIR PUBLIC LIBRARY

Architectural Selection Committee

Process Summary and Recommendation

Prepared for the Board of Trustees

October 16, 2026

Executive Summary

The Architectural Selection Committee was established to conduct a rigorous, transparent process for selecting the architecture firm that will design the transformative renovation and expansion of the Montclair Public Library's Main Library and Bellevue Avenue Branch under the NJEDA CAFE grant. After reviewing submissions from more than twenty firms, conducting scored evaluations, holding in-person presentations with five shortlisted firms, checking references, and negotiating a best-and-final fee, the Committee unanimously recommends the appointment of

DIG Architecture (also referred to as DIGroup Architecture)

as the architect for RFP #26-01.

DIG ranked first among all respondents on the Committee's technical scoring (average 52/65) with tight agreement across members. The firm demonstrated strong relevant experience with New Jersey public libraries, historic buildings, and complex public projects; a collaborative approach; and a competitive fixed fee of $2,050,500 (Best and Final Offer dated October 14, 2026). The Board of Trustees has ultimate authority to appoint the firm. This briefing is provided so that all Trustees, including those who did not participate directly in the Committee, are fully informed ahead of the formal decision.

Project Context

The project involves the concurrent design and construction of two buildings:

- Main Library: gut renovation with major additions
- Bellevue Avenue Branch (Carnegie building): addition and renovation

Both buildings will close simultaneously to meet the four-year construction deadline tied to the NJEDA CAFE grant—the largest state-supported library construction award in New Jersey history and the first library project to receive tax-credit financing. Program elements (including a teaching kitchen, children's makerspace, and other grant-committed spaces) are locked. LEED Silver certification is required. The selected firm must navigate NJ SHPO and Historic Preservation Commission (HPC) review, deliver on an aggressive schedule targeting construction start by the end of 2027, and partner with the Library on community engagement.

Committee Composition

The Committee was deliberately cross-functional, drawing expertise from the Library, Foundation, Friends, Township, Historic Preservation Commission, and professional project management support. All members are listed below:

- Radwa Ali — Montclair Public Library Executive Director (Committee Facilitator)
- Renee Baskerville — Township Mayor
- Kathleen M. Bennett — Montclair Historic Preservation Commission, Chairperson
- Eileen Brackenbury — Foundation Board (Historic Preservationist)
- Adam Grace — Library Friends
- Ted Graham — Library Board Vice President / Buildings & Grounds Chair
- Bill Harrison — Town Councilor
- Tom Hoesly — Library Staff (Patron Services)
- JoAnn McCullough — Library Board of Trustees, President
- George Oliphant — Foundation Board of Directors

- Mary Packer — Foundation Executive Director
- John Reimnitz — Montclair Historic Preservation Commission, Member / Architect
- Edward Robin — Library Friends
- Enola Romano — Library Staff (Youth Services)
- Paul Sionas — Library Board of Trustees / Architect
- Janice Talley — Township Planner
- Kathleen Tartaglia & Joel Lizotte — Professional project management support for the selection process

Kathleen Tartaglia and Joel Lizotte provided professional services as project manager supporting the Library and Committee throughout the architect selection process. A separate procurement will be required for construction management services.

Selection Process Overview

The Committee chose a single-step RFP process (rather than a two-phase RFQ followed by RFP) to evaluate qualifications, approach, and cost efficiently while retaining full decision authority. Key milestones:

1. **June 2026:** Committee kickoff; RFP framework and criteria developed; Board approval of RFP.
2. **July–August 2026:** RFP #26-01 issued publicly and to invited firms. Addenda issued as needed.
3. **August 2026:** Submissions received (more than 20 firms). Technical proposals scored independently by Committee members using a consistent rubric (criteria A–K totaling 65 points). Fee proposals were evaluated separately.
4. **Early September 2026:** Scores compiled. DIG ranked first (avg. 52/65) with tight agreement, followed closely by Clarke Caton Hintz and Sage and Coombe (both ~49.7).
5. **Mid-September 2026:** Shortlist of five firms selected for interviews: DIG, Clarke Caton Hintz, Sage and Coombe, Arcari + Iovino, and PS&S.
6. **Late September–early October 2026:** In-person presentations (approximately 60 minutes + 30 minutes Q&A) held for all five firms. Recordings shared with the full Committee.
7. **October 6, 2026:** Committee discussion following presentations. Strong support emerged for DIG among members present.
8. **October 7–14, 2026:** DIG requested to provide a Best and Final Offer. References contacted (Long Branch Public Library, Union County Improvement Authority, Warren County Library, Montclair Veterans Services). Fee questions clarified.
9. **October 15, 2026:** Final Committee meeting. Unanimous recommendation of DIG. Materials (BAFO, references, Q&As) circulated in advance.

Technical Scoring Criteria

Each firm was scored independently by Committee members on eleven technical criteria totaling 65 points. Cost/fee was evaluated separately and is not part of this ranking. The criteria were:

- **A — New Jersey public library experience (up to 8 points):** Has the firm successfully designed public libraries in New Jersey? Library-specific operational needs are complex; prior experience was a top priority.

- **B — New Jersey construction of similar size/complexity (up to 8 points):** Has the firm completed comparable-scale public or institutional projects in New Jersey?
- **C — NJEDA / CAFE experience (up to 4 points):** Familiarity with New Jersey Economic Development Authority programs and the specific constraints of the CAFE grant.
- **D — Historic preservation & NJ SHPO (up to 10 points):** Experience with the Secretary of the Interior's Standards and navigating New Jersey State Historic Preservation Office and local Historic Preservation Commission review. Critical for the Carnegie Bellevue branch.
- **E — Dual-building / mixed-program analogues (up to 6 points):** Experience designing two distinct buildings or complex mixed-use programs at the same time.
- **F — Named personnel assigned (up to 8 points):** Quality and relevance of the specific people proposed for the project, not just the firm's general reputation.
- **G — Budget performance on comparable work (up to 6 points):** Track record of delivering projects on or near budget, especially renovations.
- **H — Schedule performance (up to 3 points):** Ability to meet aggressive timelines.
- **I — Community engagement / public process (up to 5 points):** Experience planning and leading meaningful public input and translating it into design.
- **J — Sustainability / operational efficiency (up to 5 points):** Ability to achieve LEED Silver and design for long-term operational efficiency.
- **K — Clarity & completeness of proposal (up to 2 points):** How clearly and completely the firm responded to the RFP.

Technical Scoring Results

Technical scores (out of 65) were compiled from 12 Committee member scoresheets. DIG led the field with the highest average and tight agreement among scorers.

Firm	Avg /65	Median	Agreement
DIG Architecture (M/DBE)	**52.0**	52.0	Tight
Clarke Caton Hintz	49.7	50.0	Tight
Sage and Coombe Architects	49.7	49.5	Tight
Arcari + Iovino Architects	49.5	49.5	Some spread
PS&S	48.3	50.0	Some spread

Source: MPL Architect Committee Scoring Summary (compiled from 12 scoresheets). Full matrix and criterion-level detail available in Committee materials.

DIG scored particularly well on named personnel (F), budget performance (G), schedule performance (H), historic preservation (D), and clarity of proposal (K). Its strength in New Jersey library and public-project experience was a key factor in its ranking.

Presentations and Committee Discussion

All five shortlisted firms presented in person in late September and early October 2026. Each firm addressed the Committee's presentation prompt covering vision for both buildings, design process, community engagement, support for a first-time capital owner, balancing stakeholder input with function/cost/code, approach to non-traditional spaces (Fab Lab, café, teaching kitchen), LEED Silver in a historic Carnegie building, accessibility, and schedule management.

Following the presentations, the Committee reconvened on October 6. Members present expressed strong, unanimous support for DIG as the preferred firm. DIG was identified as the

front-runner; Clarke Caton Hintz was viewed as a strong second. The Committee directed staff to request a Best and Final Offer from DIG and to complete reference checks.

On October 15 the Committee met again, reviewed the BAFO, references, and clarifying responses, and confirmed its unanimous recommendation of DIG. Individual members who could not attend the final meeting had previously communicated their support.

DIG Architecture — Key Strengths and References

DIG is an M/DBE firm with demonstrated experience on New Jersey public library projects (including Long Branch Public Library's Carnegie and 1960s sections) and large public works for the Union County Improvement Authority (projects totaling more than $180 million). Committee members noted the firm's collaborative culture, responsiveness, and ability to balance design quality with budget and operational realities.

Reference Highlights

- Long Branch Public Library (Tonya Garcia): Called DIG "the best professional firm that I've worked with in twenty-three years." Praised responsiveness, listening to staff, historic sensitivity, and accurate cost estimates. Project stayed within budget.
- Union County Improvement Authority (Bibi Taylor): "True partner" across a $150 million government complex and other projects. Strong budget management, contractor accountability, and operational sensitivity. Would hire again without hesitation.
- Warren County Library (Kelly Durkin): Receptive team; beautiful result. Advised emphasizing day-to-day library function over aesthetics and recommended a dedicated construction manager with the library remaining in the driver's seat.
- Montclair Veterans Services (James Evers): Collaborative and accessible team; graceful handling of administrative issues.

Township Planner Janice Talley reviewed DIG's fee structure and confirmed it "looks good." Committee architects raised clarifying questions on technology consulting, specifications, furniture/shelving scope, and consultant rates; these were addressed by reference to the RFP (certain items by Owner) and DIG's proposal. The fee is fixed.

Fee Proposal

DIG submitted a Best and Final Offer of

$2,050,500

for Professional Services (letter dated October 14, 2026). This is a fixed fee that maintains the original scope of services, project team, consultant disciplines, and level of commitment. It reflects a significant reduction from the firm's earlier proposal while preserving the work product the Committee evaluated. All other assumptions and clarifications from the August 19 proposal remain in effect.

The Committee views this fee as competitive and appropriate for the scale, complexity, and dual-building nature of the project, particularly given DIG's technical ranking and reference feedback on budget performance.

Recommendation

The Architectural Selection Committee unanimously recommends that the Board of Trustees appoint

DIG Architecture

as the architect for the Montclair Public Library renovation and expansion project (RFP #26-01) at the Best and Final Offer fee of $2,050,500.

This recommendation is based on:

- Highest technical ranking with tight Committee agreement
- Strong relevant experience with NJ public libraries, historic buildings, and complex public projects
- Positive, detailed reference feedback confirming collaboration, budget discipline, and client satisfaction
- Competitive fixed fee that reflects negotiation
- Alignment with the Library's need for a collaborative partner experienced in community process, SHPO/HPC navigation, and aggressive schedules
- Unanimous support of Committee members who participated in the final deliberations

DIG has been invited to attend the Board of Trustees meeting on October 19, 2026 (presentation limited to approximately 30 minutes plus Q&A). The Committee stands ready to answer any questions Trustees may have.

Next Steps

- Board of Trustees considers and votes on the appointment of DIG at its October 19, 2026 meeting.
- Upon approval, staff and counsel will execute the professional services agreement consistent with the BAFO and RFP terms.
- Immediate kickoff activities will include team introductions, schedule confirmation, and initiation of the design and community-engagement process.
- A separate procurement process will be conducted for construction management services.

Respectfully submitted,
Architectural Selection Committee
Montclair Public Library
October 16, 2026